UZBEK CLANSMEN AND A KING IN THE NORTH

When Humayun rode back to Kabul from Persia in 1545, there were six Uzbek noblemen with him including the two brothers Ali Quli Khan and Bahadur Khan. They remained loyal during Humayun's many battles with his brothers and fought with distinction in the battles for Hindustan. By the time Akbar became Padshah in 1556, they were second only to the Timurid mirzas in hierarchy and their tight-knit family group gave them a unity of purpose rare in this shifting, mercurial early empire. The Uzbeks were given charge of the eastern region as well as the Punjab and Multan, giving them more land than any other clan in the Mughal Empire. When the Afghans of the east attempted rebellion under the banner of Sher Shah Sur, the Uzbeks defeated them at Jaunpur but then maintained worryingly friendly relations with them. The Afghans, with their own pretensions to empire since the Sur dynasty, could never be incorporated into the Timurid-led Mughal Empire and so this rapprochement between the Uzbeks and the Afghan rulers of Rohtas, Bihar, and Bengal not only made them a formidable group but one that made the Persians and the Turanis profoundly uncomfortable.

Akbar had realized early in his reign that the concentration of jagirs held by clans in one particular region was dangerous. It made the nobility territorial, recalcitrant, and made it harder to control revenue transfer to the crown. Akbar started taking measures relatively early to fragment the jagirs of the nobility and to ensure frequent transfers of these powerful men. He brought in administrative reforms, requiring the nobility to submit accounts of revenues—especially galling to the clans controlling outlying provinces, who had enjoyed a considerable absence of oversight. Akbar also now separated the department of finance (diwani) from the jurisdiction of the wakil, Munim Khan, and instead placed it under a separate official directly responsible to the Padshah. This new post, the wazirat-i-diwan-ikul, was an important departure from Humayun's reign and brought financial and administrative control to the centre. He also brought in the office of the mir bakshi, to oversee the army, the khan-i-saman, in charge of the royal household, and the sadr with powers over the judiciary. All these changes